sow thorns; for they will prick your feet. We are all one body, Whoever tortures another, wounds himself.' But it was the more worldly Khushal Khan Khattak who appealed to Elphinstone's Enlightenment heart. Khushal was a tribal leader who had revolted against the Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb and eluded his armies as they chased him through the passes of the Hindu Kush. In his diary, Elphinstone compared him to William Wallace, the medieval Scottish freedom fighter: 'Sometimes succeeding in destroying royal armies, sometimes wandering almost alone through the mountains'. But, unlike Wallace, Khushal Khan was also a fine poet:

> Fair and rosy are the girls of Adam Khel . . .
> Slender of belly, their breasts full and firm,
>
> Like the hawk has been my flight upon the mountains,
> And many a pretty partridge has been my prey.
>
> Love's affairs are like fire, O Khushal,
> Though the flame be hidden, the smoke is seen.[36]

Or, more succinctly:

> There is a boy across the river with a bottom like a peach
> But alas! I cannot swim.[37]

The Embassy marched into Peshawar six months after leaving Delhi, and was lodged in a large courtyard house off the main bazaar. Just as Elphinstone's Scottish Enlightenment education determined the way he responded to Afghan poetry, so when the time finally came for his first audience with Shah Shuja, the Ambassador's reading guided the way he perceived the Durrani monarch. On his way towards Peshawar, Elphinstone had been immersed in Tacitus' account of the German tribes confronting the Roman Empire, and in his diary he transposed the action to his current situation: he imagined the Afghans to be like the wild Germanic tribes, while the 'decadent Persians' were the soft and dissolute Romans. Yet when he was finally led in to see the Shah, Elphinstone was astonished by how different the cultured Shuja was from his expectations of a rough barbarian chief from the mountains: 'The King of Kabul was a handsome man,' wrote Elphinstone,